

Qt 5

The next version of Qt, the framework used by KDE, is coming soon, but will be a much easier transition than Qt 3 / 4 was

KDE SC 5?

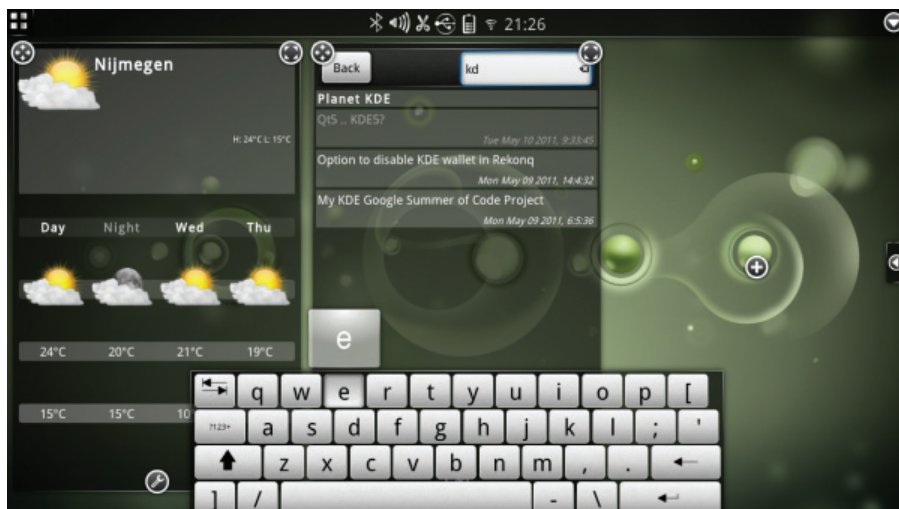
While KDE is based on Qt, KDE SC 5 won't immediately be released. KDE SC 5 will likely be a minor update unlike KDE SC 4.0

Open Source

Active apps

Just an OS designed for a tablet form factor doesn't cut it. The KDE developers realise that the way people interact with tablets is different from how they interact with mobiles, which is different from how they interact with desktops. Each form factor needs attention and the same UI can't be reused.

The frameworks that KDE is built on make it simple to separate design from data and functionality, such that it isn't a major effort to create new user interfaces for popular KDE SC applications. Some applications are already available in touch-friendly



Activity switcher

forms; these include Calligra Active, an office suite like LibreOffice / OpenOffice and Microsoft Office and Marble, a map application like Google maps.

Operating systems

This is still Linux, still open source, so Plasma Active isn't something that will be restricted to only one distro. Traditionally, the KDE community only releases the source code of the desktop environment and software, and different Linux distribution creators compile and package KDE for their distros. However, when it comes to the mobile platform (or even Windows) this method doesn't work well.

KDE needs a different approach, since unlike Android it's created and maintained by a community, not a corporation. This time around KDE will need to provide the OS stack as well, and for that

they've started working with OpenSLX, rather than creating their own distro.

Vendor interaction

One of the most important things, in the end, for any software product is that it reaches users and they use it. For a system running on a tablet, this requires some support from the creators of the tablet.

Unlike a PC, where one can install new operating systems, dual-boot or install an OS in a virtual machine, such is not possible in a tablet. On a tablet one expects to get a pre-installed OS, which the end user is unlikely to change. KDE developers can't just rely on people to install KDE by themselves; they will have to interact with vendors to have the software pre-installed on tablet devices.

These five tracks will need to be worked on in parallel if KDE SC is to reach tablet devices, and the good news is that the progress till now has been remarkable. One

Virtual keyboard

can already download images of Plasma Active for tablets. The issue, however, is that you need to have a tablet to actually test it properly.

Linux is everywhere when it comes to non-PC devices. Android is Linux, webOS is Linux, Bada is Linux yet none of these operating systems can tap into the plethora of ready-made Linux applications out there, since they use custom SDKs. This means that Linux applications can't directly run on such operating systems and application written for such OSs can't directly run on Linux.

This is where MeeGo and KDE Plasma Active shine. Both can run standard Linux applications, and applications written specially for these systems will likewise run on normal Linux distros. This means that the development resources that go into such platforms help Linux as a whole by increasing the number of quality applications available for it.

While some KDE fans might be worried that a new tablet-centric direction will mean decreased focus on their desktop environment, this isn't true. The desktop work will continue as normal, and in fact, the work done to make KDE components and applications more efficient in memory usage, better consumption and CPU usage should pay off for desktop users as well. As a major initiative by the creators of one of the most prominent and modern desktop environments for Linux, KDE Plasma Active is something to look out for. If successful, it could bring a big change to the mobile device ecosystem. ■